

[KAI[FRAME] · FTM MASC BUILD PROTOCOL · v1.0]

ENGINEER YOUR FRAME.

24 MONTHS · GYM-BASED · BUILT FOR FTM + TRANSMASC BODIES

FREE. ALWAYS.

24

months

4

days/week

<45

mins/session

0

gatekeeping

[00 · FROM KAI]

READ THIS FIRST.

No fluff. This is a 24-month body protocol built specifically for FTM and transmasculine bodies. The goal is to engineer a masculine frame through resistance training, smart nutrition, and understanding how your body actually works.

Assumptions: you have gym access, you're past P3 of male puberty naturally or 12+ months into HRT. If you're not there yet — this still works. The timeline might differ slightly but the principles are identical.

[KAI · DIRECT]

"I built this because the fitness industry either ignores us or gives us watered-down BS. You deserve the real program. So here it is. Read every section before you start."

— kai · kai[frame]

[01 · MYTH BUSTING]

THE LIES FITNESS SOLD YOU.

01

"You need muscle to be a man"

You're already a man. Muscle is a tool for your goals — confidence, health, silhouette. Not a requirement for your identity.

02

"Train hard or you're not masculine"

Smart > hard. Progressive overload + recovery = actual results. Grinding yourself into the dirt weekly = injury and burnout.

03

"Cardio kills your gains"

Low-intensity cardio (walking, cycling, swimming) has near-zero impact on muscle gains. Recent research shows it can actually boost total muscle development.

04

"Eat less to lose weight faster"

Below ~1400 cals damages your organs. Slow cuts (0.5lb/week) preserve muscle, keep you full, reduce loose skin. Faster is not better.

05

"Crunches burn belly fat"

Spot reduction is fiction. Fat loss is systemic — it comes off based on genetics and total body fat %. Lower total body fat % instead.

06

"Exercise turns fat into muscle"

Different biological processes. Fat loss needs a caloric deficit. Muscle growth needs protein + stimulus. You can do both but they're separate.

KNOW THE VOCAB.

Learn these before you touch the workouts. Non-negotiable.

TERM	WHAT IT MEANS
Rep	One complete motion of an exercise. 8 reps = 8 full movements.
Set	A group of reps. 3x8 = do 8 reps, rest, repeat 3 times total.
RPE	Rate of Perceived Exertion. 8 = 2 reps left. 9 = 1 left. 10 = failure. Aim for 8-9 most sets.
RIR	Reps In Reserve. "2 RIR" = you could do 2 more. Stay at 1-2 RIR on most sets.
Tempo	Speed of each phase. "2-1-2" = 2s down, 1s pause, 2s up. Slowing down = more gains.
Eccentric	The lowering phase — muscle lengthens. Where gains actually happen. Never rush this.
Concentric	The push/pull phase — muscle shortens. Curling up = concentric.
Superset	Two exercises back-to-back with zero rest. Brutal. Efficient. Great for volume.
Drop Set	Hit failure, drop weight immediately, keep going. Final sets only. Don't overuse.
Deload	A planned lighter week every 4-8 weeks. Not weakness — prevents burnout and injury.
TDEE	Total Daily Energy Expenditure. How many calories you burn daily. Nutrition math starts here.
Bulk / Cut	Bulk = small caloric surplus to grow muscle. Cut = small deficit to lose fat. Both should be slow.

[03 · PHASE 01 · MONTHS 0-6]

FOUNDATION.

LEARN YOUR BODY.

Upper/lower split · 4 days/week · under 45 mins · movement quality over weight. Build the patterns that all future gains run on. Don't skip this phase because it looks easy.

[KAI · DIRECT]

"Movement quality over weight. Always. I don't care if the guy next to you is squatting twice what you are. You're learning patterns. Get them right now or pay for it later with an injury."

— kai

DAY 1 — LOWER A (stability focus)

EXERCISE	SETS & REPS	TEMPO	NOTES
Lunges	4 × 10/leg	2-1-2	Drive UP not forward. Feel the glute contract at top.
Hip Thrusts	3 × 15	2-0-3	Slow and controlled. Squeeze at the top for a full second.
Calf Raises	4 × 12	1-0-3	Fast up, SLOW down. Full stretch at the bottom.

DAY 2 — UPPER A (stability focus)

EXERCISE	SETS & REPS	TEMPO	NOTES
Bicep Curls	3 × 8	3-1-2	Full extension at bottom. Don't swing.
Tricep Extensions	3 × 8	3-1-2	Lock elbows. Only forearms move.
Push-Ups	4 × 12	2-0-2	Incline if needed. Full ROM or don't count it.
Knee Tucks	3 × 15	1-1-3	Slow the eccentric. Feel the abs stretching.

DAY 3 — LOWER B (strength focus)

EXERCISE	SETS & REPS	TEMPO	NOTES
Squats	4 × 6	2-1-2	Heavier day. Test your limits. Depth matters.
Hip Thrusts	3 × 6	2-0-3	Load it up compared to Day 1.
Hamstring Curls	4 × 10-12	2-1-3	Slow eccentric is the whole point here.
Leg Abductions	3 × 12-15	1-1-1	Cable or machine. Control the movement.

DAY 4 — UPPER B (strength focus)

EXERCISE	SETS & REPS	TEMPO	NOTES
Low Rows	4 × 8-10	1-0-2	Squeeze shoulder blades. Row to your stomach.
Bench Press	2 × 12-15	2-1-2	Learn the bar path. Chest to bar, full lockout.
Assisted Pull-Ups	4 × 8-10	2-0-2	Use machine or bands. Full hang at bottom.
Knee Tucks	3 × 15	1-1-3	Same as Day 2. Feel the stretch.

[04 · PHASE 02 · MONTHS 6-12]

FRAME BUILD.

V-TAPER SEASON.

Lats, shoulders, triceps. Geometry is your best friend. Track weights every single session — progressive overload starts now.

[KAI · DIRECT]

"V-taper season. Lats, shoulders, triceps. This is what makes your upper body look wide and your waist look narrow without changing your waist at all. Track your weights every single session."

— kai

DAY 1 — LOWER

EXERCISE	SETS & REPS	TEMPO	NOTES
Squats	4 × 6-10	2-0-2	Progressive overload starts now. Add 5lb when you hit top of range.
Hip Thrusts	3 × 12-15	1-1-1	Loaded. Should be uncomfortable by rep 12.
Hamstring Curls	3 × 8-15	1-1-3	Eccentric emphasis. Let it stretch at the bottom.
Calf Raises	4 × 8-12	2-0-2	Full range. Don't bounce at the bottom.

DAY 2 — UPPER PUSH

EXERCISE	SETS & REPS	TEMPO	NOTES
Flat Bench Press	5 × 6-10	1-0-2	Main chest builder. Prioritize it fresh.
Forearm Curls	3 × 10-18	1-1-2	Bigger forearms = hands look bigger. Non-negotiable for masc read.
Tricep Extensions	2 × 10-15	1-1-2	Triceps = 2/3 of arm size. Don't sleep on these.
Bicep Curls	3 × 6-12	2-0-2	Full stretch at the bottom. That's the growth stimulus.

DAY 3 — LOWER + CORE

EXERCISE	SETS & REPS	TEMPO	NOTES
RDLs	4 × 10-15	2-1-2	Hinge at hips. Feel the stretch. Don't round your back.
Farmer's Carries	3 × 60 sec	N/A	Heavy. Shoulders back. Walk slowly.
Leg Extensions	3 × 8-12	1-1-2	Slow at the top. Don't let it drop back down.
Hamstring Curls	3 × 8-12	1-1-3	Second hamstring session this week — volume builds size.

DAY 4 — UPPER PULL

EXERCISE	SETS & REPS	TEMPO	NOTES
Dumbbell Incline Bench	3 × 6-8	2-0-2	Upper chest fills out the square chest look.
Low Rows	4 × 8-10	2-0-2	V-taper builder. Drive elbows back and down.
Bicep Curls	3 × 10-12	3-1-2	Slow today. Time under tension is the focus.
Tricep Skis (Pushdowns)	3 × 10-12	3-1-2	Elbows pinned to sides. Full extension every rep.
Leg Raises	3 × 15	1-1-3	Lower the legs S L O W. No momentum.

[05 · PHASE 03 · MONTHS 12-24]

FULL BODYBUILDING PROTOCOL.

Newbie gains are done. 5 days/week, heavier compounds, actual bodybuilding methodology. Read the progression section carefully — it matters more now than it ever did.

[KAI · DIRECT]

"Newbie gains are done. Good. That means you built the base. Now the real work starts. 5 days, heavier compounds, actual bodybuilding. Progress will be slower — that's normal. Trust the process and the data."

— kai

DAY 1 — LOWER MODERATE

EXERCISE	SETS & REPS	TEMPO	NOTES
Squats	5 × 8-12	1-0-2	Drive through the heel. Full depth.
RDLs	3 × 6-10	2-1-1	Hinge hard. Long eccentric.
Farmer's Carries	3 × 60 sec	N/A	Heavy and controlled.

DAY 2 — UPPER PUSH + PULL

EXERCISE	SETS & REPS	TEMPO	NOTES
Bench Press	5 × 6-8	2-0-2	Primary chest builder. Go heavy here.
Rows	5 × 6-8	3-1-2	Squeeze blades. Row to your stomach.
Tricep Skis	4 × 10-12	3-1-2	Elbows locked. Full extension.
Bicep Curls	4 × 10-12	3-1-2	Slow all the way down every rep.

DAY 3 — LOWER HEAVY

EXERCISE	SETS & REPS	TEMPO	NOTES
Deadlifts	5 × 3-5	Form focus	Brace hard. Drive the floor away.
RDLs (light)	3 × 10-12	2-1-2	Back off weight vs Day 1.
Hip Thrusts	3 × 12-15	2-0-3	Full squeeze at the top.
Abductor + Adductor	3 × 10-12 each	1-1-3	Controlled. Both directions.

DAY 4 — UPPER PUSH + CORE

EXERCISE	SETS & REPS	TEMPO	NOTES
Incline Bench	5 × 6-10	1-0-1	Upper chest priority.
Bicep Curls	4 × 10-12	2-1-2	Slow eccentric every rep.
Behind-the-Back Tricep Ext.	4 × 10-12	2-1-2	Lock elbows. Full stretch.
Suitcase Marches	3 × 60 sec	N/A	Core + oblique stability.
Leg Raises	4 × 10	1-0-2	Lower slowly. No swinging.

DAY 5 — BACK + SHOULDERS (V-taper day)

EXERCISE	SETS & REPS	TEMPO	NOTES
Lat Pulldowns	4 × 8-12	1-1-3	Mid-width grip. Controlled eccentric. V-taper HQ.
Chest-Supported Rows	4 × 5-10	1-1-2	Chest on pad removes cheating. Pure back work.
Lateral Raises	5 × 12-15	1-0-2	Width = masculine silhouette. Your secret weapon.
Shoulder Press	5 × 10-15	1-0-2	Full range. Don't lock out — keep tension.

HOW TO ACTUALLY GET STRONGER.

[KAI · DIRECT]

"Track. Your. Weights. I don't care if it's in your notes app, a journal, or a napkin. If you don't know what you lifted last week, you can't progress. This is non-negotiable. You're an engineer now. Engineers have data."

– kai

RULE	WHAT TO DO
Hit top of rep range?	Add 5lb next session. Always try to progress weight first.
Can't add weight?	Add 1-2 reps per set instead. Hold for 1-2 sessions then retry.
Can't add reps either?	Add one set for 2-4 weeks, then attempt a weight increase again.
At failure too often?	Stop 1-2 reps short of failure on most sets. Final set only for true failure.
Rest between sets?	Big muscles (legs, chest, back): 2-2.5 min. Small (arms, shoulders): 1.5 min.
When to deload?	Every 4-8 weeks drop to 60% of your normal volume for one full week.
Testing your failure point?	2-4x per month per major lift. You can't push close to failure without knowing where it is.

FTM SPECIFIC: HORMONES + GAINS.

Higher testosterone = more muscle protein synthesis, faster recovery, higher TDEE. If you're on HRT for 6+ months, use the male TDEE calculator when estimating caloric needs. Your metabolic rate has shifted — running pre-T calculations will have you eating below maintenance without realizing it.

TOPIC	WHAT IT MEANS FOR YOU
T + Muscle Building	More muscle protein synthesis = faster recovery = higher TDEE. You're working with a hormonal environment built for this.
Fat Redistribution	T shifts fat from hips/thighs to abdominal distribution over time. Combined with upper body training, this creates the frame shift you're after.
TDEE on HRT 6+ months	Use male TDEE calculator. Your metabolic rate has shifted. Pre-T calculations leave you eating below maintenance without realizing it.
Height + Frame Reality	Shoulder-to-waist ratio and posture do more work for passing than height ever will. Build lats, shoulders, and arms.
Pre-T or early transition	This program still works. The timeline might look slightly different but the principles and all progression rules are identical.

[08 · NUTRITION]

EAT LIKE YOU MEAN IT.

[KAI · DIRECT]

"Calorie tracking apps are great if you can use them without it messing with your head. If they cause anxiety or disordered thinking, use the hand-portion method instead. Both work. Pick the one you'll actually stick to."

— kai

MACRO TARGETS (example: 190lb, 5'10")

Use a TDEE calculator for your specific numbers. For HRT 6mo+, calculate as male.

MACRO	TARGET	NOTES
Protein	0.7-1g/lb bodyweight (160-190g)	Priority #1. If you hit nothing else, hit protein.
Carbohydrates	~350g	Your training fuel. Don't slash these — you need them to perform.
Fats	~75g	Hormone production. Don't go below 0.3g/lb bodyweight.
Total Calories	~2750 kcal/day	Adjust +200 for bulk, -200 to -500 for cut. Slow is always better.

HAND-PORTION METHOD (if calorie tracking triggers you)

Per meal, 4 meals/day:

FOOD GROUP	PORTION
Protein per meal	2-3 fist-sized portions
Carbs per meal	2-3 fist-sized portions
Fats per meal	One palm-size portion only
Veg + fruit per meal	3-4 portions — don't skip these

SUPPLEMENT STACK

SUPPLEMENT	DOSE	WHY
Creatine Monohydrate	5g/day	More strength, size, faster recovery. Non-negotiable. 120oz water daily.
Magnesium	250mg/day	Recovery quality and sleep depth. Most people are deficient.
Multivitamin	After 6mo	Dietary insurance only. Not a replacement for real food.

RECOVERY

Sleep minimum 7 hours. Optimal 8-9. Sleep deprivation directly reduces muscle protein synthesis, strength progression, and daily energy. It is not optional — it is when your body actually builds the muscle you trained for.

[09 · COMING NEXT]

NEWSLETTER DROPS.

You're on the list. Here's what's coming — newsletter subscribers only. No spam. No upsells. Just the program extensions.

[COMING SOON]

DIY HRT: WHAT YOU NEED TO KNOW

Self-administered HRT — pharmacology, sourcing landscape, dosing protocols, and harm reduction. No judgment. Just information.

[COMING SOON]

ADVANCED TRAINING: PERIODIZATION FOR FTM BODIES

Block periodization, peaking cycles, deload programming, and specialization phases for when you've outgrown beginner programming.

[COMING SOON]

CONFIDENCE + SOCIAL PASSING: THE REAL STUFF

Body language, vocal training, gendered spaces, building social confidence as a transmasculine person. The guide nobody wrote for us.

[COMING SOON]

FTM GROOMING: THE ACTUAL GUIDE

Beard care from day one on T, skincare for changing skin texture, haircuts for your face shape, and the grooming basics nobody taught us.

24

month protocol

4

days/week

<45

mins/session

0

gatekeeping

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